

Official Inquiries

PRESENTED BY

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Why this project?

Governments publish large amounts of high quality* information on matters of public importance in the form of reports of official inquiries.

BUT: It is published in form that makes it hard to discover and use (obscure PDFs strewn around the web)

** dedicated research effort, often independent author, subpoena powers, witnesses etc*

Examples

Senate Investigation into Financial Crisis

- The US Senate Permanent Subcommittee on Investigations produces many high-quality reports.
- Its report on the financial crisis was the original source for many of the news stories including Goldman Sachs' packaging up of subprime mortgage bonds for investors, or the poor performance of ratings agencies like Moody's.
- However, this treasure trove of information is not very easy to access. To illustrate, here are some of the steps you would have to take to get to it:

Let's assume you've found the committee website and reports subsection (not easy in itself)...

The screenshot shows the website of the Homeland Security & Governmental Affairs Permanent Subcommittee on Investigations. The top navigation bar includes links for HOME, ABOUT, SUBCOMMITTEES, HEARINGS, MEDIA, LEGISLATION & NOMINATIONS, LIBRARY, and CONTACT. The main header features the subcommittee's name and a search bar. On the left, a 'SEARCH REPORTS' sidebar allows filtering by keyword and Congress (currently set to 114). The main content area, titled 'REPORTS', shows results for the 114th Congress, with a 'MORE' dropdown. The results are organized by date, showing reports from March 2016 and January 2016.

HOME ABOUT SUBCOMMITTEES HEARINGS MEDIA LEGISLATION & NOMINATIONS LIBRARY CONTACT

Homeland Security & Governmental Affairs
PERMANENT SUBCOMMITTEE ON INVESTIGATIONS

Search SEARCH

SEARCH REPORTS

By Keyword **Go**

Refine by **Go**

REPORTS **MORE** ▼

Permanent Subcommittee on Investigations - Reports

- [GPO Links to Reports of the Permanent Subcommittee on Investigations \(1999-Present\)](#) [PDF]

Currently showing results in the **114th** Congress.

March 2016

3/10/16	Majority Staff Report - Failure of the Affordable Care Act Health Insurance CO-OPs
---------	--

January 2016

1/28/16	Majority and Minority Staff Report - Protecting Unaccompanied Alien Children from Trafficking and Other Abuses: The Role of the Office of Refugee Resettlement
---------	--

No simple search, so you have to know in which Congress the report was published ...



SEARCH REPORTS

By Keyword

Go

Refine by

114

Go

REPORTS

MORE



Permanent Subcommittee on Investigations - Reports

- [GPO Links to Reports of the Permanent Subcommittee on Investigations \(1999-Present\) \[PDF\]](#)

Currently showing results in the 114th Congress.

Note the listing itself
is in PDF!!

January 2016

1/28/16

Majority and Minority Staff Report - Protecting Unaccompanied Alien Children from

There is a nice link at the top containing links to all the subcommittee's reports, but it is PDF ...

The PDF contains the links...

Updated 2/10/16

**LINKS TO PRINTED
UNITED STATES SENATE
PERMANENT SUBCOMMITTEE ON INVESTIGATIONS
Hearings & Reports
106th – 114th Congresses**

106th CONGRESS
Susan Collins, Chairman
Carl Levin, Ranking Minority Member

HEARINGS

Deceptive Mailings and Sweepstakes Promotions

(March 8 and 9, 1999) (S. Hrg. 106-71)

LINK TO HEARING: [CLICK HERE](#)

Securities Fraud on the Internet

(March 22 and 23, 1999) (S. Hrg. 106-137)

LINK TO HEARING: [CLICK HERE](#)

Home Health Care: Will The New Payment System and Regulatory Overkill Hurt Our Seniors?

(June 10, 1999) (S. Hrg. 106-197)

LINK TO HEARING: [CLICK HERE](#)

The Hidden Operators of Deceptive Mailings

(July 20, 1999) (S. Hrg. 106-181)

LINK TO HEARING: [CLICK HERE](#)

Day Trading: An Overview

(September 16, 1999) (S. Hrg. 106-285)

LINK TO HEARING: [CLICK HERE](#)

Conquering Diabetes: Are We Taking Full Advantage of the Scientific Opportunities for Research?

(October 14, 1999) (S. Hrg. 106-304)

LINK TO HEARING: [CLICK HERE](#)

Private Banking and Money Laundering: A Case Study of Opportunities and Vulnerabilities

(November 9 and 10, 1999) (S. Hrg. 106-428)

LINK TO HEARING: [CLICK HERE](#)

Day Trading: Everyone Gambles but the House

(February 24 and 25, 2000) (S. Hrg. 106-505)

LINK TO HEARING: [CLICK HERE](#)

Oversight of HCFA's Settlement Policies: Did HCFA Give Three Providers Special Treatment?

(March 28, 2000) (S. Hrg. 106-521)

LINK TO HEARING: [CLICK HERE](#)

But those links are not always reliable...

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Content Unavailable - The content you requested is not available.

This standard message is returned when content or documents (public laws, congressional bills, etc.) are not yet available on FDsys.

If you get this message, please verify the URL is correct. If the URL is correct, the content has not yet been published for online access.

If you believe you received this message in error, please report this problem to contactcenter@gpo.gov.

Please provide the following information to help us resolve this problem: the URL of the page you were trying to access, the steps you followed to produce the error, and/or a screenshot of the page where the error occurred.

Thank you for your patience.

Please consider the following resources:

[FDsys Home Page](#)

[GPO Home Page](#)

[GPO Site Map](#)

[GO BACK](#)

If we take the link to our report, we end up at the GPO website, where we have to navigate through another directory hierarchy to find the right committee (after working out which committee the subcommittee reports to!)

Visit the website:

Purchase congressional hearings from the **U.S. Government Online Bookstore**.

Locate the congressional hearings in a local **Federal depository library**.



publications may also be browsed via the FDsys [congressional committee browse page](#).

FDsys contains selected House and Senate hearings for the 105th Congress (1997-98) forward. The House and Senate appropriations hearings for fiscal year 1998 forward are also included. Documents are available as text and PDF. Graphics, including scanned images of camera ready copy are omitted from the ASCII text version but are contained in the PDF files. [About the Congressional Hearings](#).

⊕ [114th Congress \(2015 - 2016\)](#)

⊕ [113th Congress \(2013 - 2014\)](#)

⊕ [112th Congress \(2011 - 2012\)](#)

⊕ [House Hearings](#)

⊕ [Joint Hearings](#)

⊕ [Senate Hearings](#)

⊕ [Committee on Agriculture, Nutrition, and Forestry](#)

⊕ [Committee on Appropriations](#)

⊕ [Committee on Armed Services](#)

⊕ [Committee on Banking, Housing, and Urban Affairs](#)

⊕ [Committee on Commerce, Science, and Transportation](#)

⊕ [Committee on Energy and Natural Resources](#)

⊕ [Committee on Environment and Public Works](#)

⊕ [Committee on Finance](#)

⊕ [Committee on Foreign Relations](#)

⊕ [Committee on Health, Education, Labor, and Pensions](#)

⊕ [Committee on Homeland Security and Governmental Affairs](#)

S. Hrg. 112-41 - GULF COAST RECOVERY: AN EXAMINATION OF CLAIMS AND SOCIAL SERVICES IN THE AFTERMATH OF THE...

[General](#). Thursday, January 27, 2011.

[PDF](#) | [Text](#) | [More](#)

S. Hrg. 112-42 - IMPROVING FEDERAL CONTRACT AUDITING

[General](#). Tuesday, February 1, 2011.

[PDF](#) | [Text](#) | [More](#)

Wouldn't a simple search box have been nice?

But wait a minute: the report is separated into four unsearchable PDFs and each volume is nearly 100mb...

General. Monday, May 21, 2012.

[PDF](#) | [Text](#) | [More](#)

S. Hrg. 112-670 - ASSESSING GRANTS MANAGEMENT PRACTICES AT FEDERAL AGENCIES

General. Wednesday, July 25, 2012.

[PDF](#) | [Text](#) | [More](#)

S. Hrg. 112-675, PART III - WALL STREET AND THE FINANCIAL CRISIS: ANATOMY OF A FINANCIAL COLLAPSE

General. Wednesday, April 13, 2011.

[PDF](#) | [Text](#) | [More](#)

S. Hrg. 112-675, PART II - WALL STREET AND THE FINANCIAL CRISIS: ANATOMY OF A FINANCIAL COLLAPSE

General. Wednesday, April 13, 2011.

[PDF](#) | [Text](#) | [More](#)

S. Hrg. 112-675, PART I - WALL STREET AND THE FINANCIAL CRISIS: ANATOMY OF A FINANCIAL COLLAPSE

General. Wednesday, April 13, 2011.

[PDF](#) | [Text](#) | [More](#)

S. Hrg. 112-675, Part IV - WALL STREET AND THE FINANCIAL CRISIS: ANATOMY OF A FINANCIAL COLLAPSE

General. Wednesday, April 13, 2011.

[PDF](#) | [Text](#) | [More](#)

S. Hrg. 112-675, Volume 5 - [ERRATA] WALL STREET AND THE FINANCIAL CRISIS: ANATOMY OF A FINANCIAL COLLAPSE

General. Wednesday, April 13, 2011.

[PDF](#) | [Text](#) | [More](#)

S. Hrg. 112-675, Volume 5 - [ERRATA] WALL STREET AND THE FINANCIAL CRISIS: ANATOMY OF A FINANCIAL COLLAPSE

General. Wednesday, April 13, 2011.

[PDF](#) | [Text](#) | [More](#)

S. Hrg. 112-675, Volume 5 - [ERRATA] WALL STREET AND THE FINANCIAL CRISIS: ANATOMY OF A FINANCIAL COLLAPSE

General. Wednesday, April 13, 2011.

[PDF](#) | [Text](#) | [More](#)

S. Hrg. 112-675, Volume 5 - [ERRATA] WALL STREET AND THE FINANCIAL CRISIS: ANATOMY OF A FINANCIAL COLLAPSE

General. Wednesday, April 13, 2011.

[PDF](#) | [Text](#) | [More](#)

S. Hrg. 112-676 - CENSUS: PLANNING AHEAD FOR 2020

...and the text versions are not much use!

[GRAPHIC] [TIFF OMITTED] T7323.001

[GRAPHIC] [TIFF OMITTED] T7323.002

[GRAPHIC] [TIFF OMITTED] T7323.003

[GRAPHIC] [TIFF OMITTED] T7323.004

[GRAPHIC] [TIFF OMITTED] T7323.005

[GRAPHIC] [TIFF OMITTED] T7323.006

[GRAPHIC] [TIFF OMITTED] T7323.007

[GRAPHIC] [TIFF OMITTED] T7323.008

[GRAPHIC] [TIFF OMITTED] T7323.009

[GRAPHIC] [TIFF OMITTED] T7323.010

[GRAPHIC] [TIFF OMITTED] T7323.011

[GRAPHIC] [TIFF OMITTED] T7323.012

[GRAPHIC] [TIFF OMITTED] T7323.013

[GRAPHIC] [TIFF OMITTED] T7323.014

[GRAPHIC] [TIFF OMITTED] T7323.015

[GRAPHIC] [TIFF OMITTED] T7323.016

[GRAPHIC] [TIFF OMITTED] T7323.017

But since we now know it's the 112th Congress, we can go back to the main subcommittee website...

September 2012

9/13/12 [REPORT: PSI Minority Staff Report - Social Security Disability Programs: Improving the Quality of Benefit Award Decisions](#)

July 2012

7/17/12 [REPORT: U.S. Vulnerabilities to Money Laundering, Drugs, and Terrorist Financing: HSBC Case History](#)

December 2011

12/14/11 [REPORT ADDENDUM - PSI Majority Staff Report: Offshore Funds Located Onshore](#)

October 2011

10/20/11 [REPORT: PSI Majority Staff Report - Repatriating Offshore Funds - 2004 Tax Windfall for Select Multinationals](#)

April 2011

4/13/11 [REPORT & EXHIBIT LINKS: Wall Street & the Financial Crisis](#)

4/13/11 [REPORT: Wall Street & The Financial Crisis: Anatomy of a Financial Collapse \(Links to GPO for 4 volume report\).](#)

4/13/11 [REPORT: Wall Street & The Financial Crisis: Anatomy of a Financial Collapse](#)

This link simply takes you to same PDF of report links that we encountered earlier at the top of page!

Third time's the charm...

This one gives us a PDF with links back to the GPO site we've just been to...

...but there are three separate links!

United States Senate

PERMANENT SUBCOMMITTEE ON INVESTIGATIONS

Committee on Homeland Security and Governmental Affairs

Carl Levin, Chairman

Tom Coburn, Ranking Minority Member

WALL STREET AND THE FINANCIAL CRISIS: Anatomy of a Financial Collapse

**MAJORITY AND MINORITY
STAFF REPORT**

**PERMANENT SUBCOMMITTEE
ON INVESTIGATIONS**

UNITED STATES SENATE



Ah; the third one is a “decent” PDF (though still in PDF)

But:

- Now I've got the report, but it's a PDF file that's over 500 pages long!
- This might be OK for desktop, but what about browsing on tablet or mobile?
- What if I want to do a full text search?
- And, if I was really thorough and went back and read the GPO's 4 volume TIFF PDFs I find that it is missing the exhibits and therefore much of the crucial information...
- And those exhibits are simply crammed into a few PDF files. Wouldn't it have made more sense to put them in a simple directory for easy browsing? Presumably that's how they started: neatly labelled and ordered on someone's hard drive!

An example from the UK:

- Let's say we wanted to access the report from the Saville Inquiry into the events of Bloody Sunday.
- This report deals with the shooting of civilians by British armed forces and assesses a previous inquiry that also looked at the events.

There is a bespoke website set up for it.

The Bloody Sunday Inquiry

The Rt Hon Lord Saville of Newdigate (Chairman)
The Hon Mr William L. Hoyt
The Hon Mr John L. Toohey

"... that a Tribunal be established for inquiring into a definite matter of urgent public importance, namely the events on Sunday 30 January 1972 which led to loss of life in connection with the procession in Londonderry on that day, taking account of any new information relevant to events on that day."

Mr Tony Blair MP, The Prime Minister
Statement to the House of Commons
29 January 1998

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So far, so good...

But if we go to the “reports and statements” page... There are no links! We cannot even navigate between pages!

These are not
links; it is simply
text that says
“download”...

You may need Adobe Acrobat Reader to view some of these files. [Click here for more information.](#)
You may need Word 97/2000 Viewer to view some of these files. [Click here for more information.](#)
Number available = 2537

Sort By Number		Sort By Date		
JP7	JP7 - Statement of S Penney	21/06/02	1194.24 kb	Download
AP12	AP12 - Statement of Daniel Gerald Porter	30/11/00	223.33 kb	Download
AR19	AR19 - Statement of John Roddy	30/11/00	367.84 kb	Download
AG51	AG51 - Statement of Leonard James Green	30/11/00	1306.18 kb	Download
AM376	AM376 - Statement of Sinead McNicholl	30/11/00	712.24 kb	Download
AM249	AM249 - Statement of Thomas McGlinchey	30/11/00	510.44 kb	Download
AT19	AT19 - Statement of Kathleen Turner (nee Donaghy)	04/12/00	2843.6 kb	Download
AM148	AM148 - Statement of Tony McCourt	04/12/00	851.31 kb	Download
AC132	AC132 - Statement of William Joseph Curran	07/12/00	711.09 kb	Download
AC130	AC130 - Statement of Betty Curran	07/12/00	522.47 kb	Download
H13	H13 - Statement of Father George McLaughlin	07/12/00	1060.06 kb	Download
AF26	AF26 - Statement of Michael Joseph Fox	13/12/00	1126.49 kb	Download
AH10	AH10 - Statement of Ann Harkin	13/12/00	1503.67 kb	Download
AO6	AO6 - Statement of Patrick O'Carolan	13/12/00	2341.06 kb	Download
AM161	AM161 - Statement of Charles McDaid	13/12/00	2451.29 kb	Download
AM217	AM 217 - Statement of Derek McFeely	15/01/01	6221.91 kb	Download
AM264	AM264 - Statement of Patricia Bridget McGowan	15/01/01	2370.87 kb	Download
AB19	AB19 - Statement of Sean Barr	17/01/01	779.59 kb	Download
AO28	AO28 - Statement of Eunan O'Donnell	18/01/01	1864.76 kb	Download
AM166	AM166 - Statement of James Joseph McDaid	18/01/01	3594.97 kb	Download
AM483	AM483 - Statement of Brendan McCrossan	18/01/01	2963 kb	Download
AL1	AL1 - Statement of Eugene John Lafferty	18/01/01	1596.27 kb	Download
AB69	AB69 - Statement of Seamus Bradley	18/01/01	2867.45 kb	Download
AM223	AM223 - Statement of John McGee	23/01/01	16280.71 kb	Download
AM170	AM170 - Statement of Monica Philomena McDaid	23/01/01	1577.16 kb	Download

These are just
text numbers.
They are not
page links...

So the site is less than useful!

If we search a bit more, we can find the report on the government's website...

Independent report

Report of the Bloody Sunday Inquiry

From: [Bloody Sunday Inquiry](#)
First published: 15 June 2010

This document contains the following information: Report of the Bloody Sunday Inquiry.

Documents



[Report of the Bloody Sunday Inquiry Volume 1](#)

Ref: ISBN 9780102964608, HC 29 2010-11
PDF, 8.68MB, 493 pages

But again, it is separated into large PDFs that run for hundreds of pages

If we want a different format, we have to actually email the National Archives and ask them to send it to us...

Documents



[Report of the Bloody Sunday Inquiry Volume](#)

I

Ref: ISBN 9780102964608, HC 29 2010-11
PDF, 8.68MB, 493 pages

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[Report of the Bloody Sunday Inquiry Volume](#)

II

Ref: ISBN 9780102964608, HC 29 2010-11
PDF, 27.1MB, 353 pages

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A simple text version would be great - but does it exist?

What Kind of Information?

- Reports of official inquiries*
 - e.g. Financial Crisis Inquiry, Leveson Report (phone hacking)
 - House Senate Investigating Committee (Carl Levin)
 - money-laundering and resources and financial crisis from here
- *[Potential future interest]: Judicial decisions and litigation*
 - *UK esp rich as a centre of international commercial litigation that is currently difficult to access*

What Do We Propose

- Collect and archive official reports (from UK and US to start)
- Structure the material - add metadata, search and browse
- Easy-to-use web interface with full text exposed for SEO
- Do storage in simple, cheap way that allows us to provide permanence (for example using Amazon S3)
- Extract text from PDFs to provide full text search

Principles

- Simple, coherent, consistent
- Permanent - simple, cheap file storage allows permanence
- Linkable - deep links into text
- Discoverable - good SEO, plain text etc

Pilot

- 5-10 major reports in UK and US
- Identify and retrieve key files by hand
- Built a website for accessing the reports
- Trial full text extraction and provide full text search
- Beautiful presentation with deep linking into the text

Outputs:

- Official Inquiries website with full text search and deep linking for ≥ 5 reports
- A repository of open and machine readable versions of the reports
- Documentation of our small pieces loosely joined architecture and approach

Help us!

- Getting involved with Official Inquiries is really easy
 - Join us at officialinquiries.atomatic.net!